

Session 6: Introduction to the Ancient TaNaK Order

Key Takeaways

- TaNaK is an acronym for Torah, Nevi'im, and Ketuvim, the three-part design of the Hebrew Bible. Jesus and other Jewish authors spoke about the Hebrew Bible using this three-part design.
- *Torah* means “teaching” in Hebrew and includes the same first five books as our English Bibles: Genesis, Exodus, Leviticus, Numbers, and Deuteronomy.
- *Nevi'im* means “prophets” in Hebrew and includes Isaiah through Malachi and begins with Joshua through Kings.
- *Ketuvim* means “the writings” in Hebrew and is similar to the poetry section of our English Bibles, but it also includes a few other books such as Ruth and Daniel.

Ancient Evidence for the Shape of the TaNaK

When Jesus alludes to the order of the Hebrew Bible, he assumes a three-part design, which agrees with other contemporary Jewish authors who allude to the ordered sections.

Luke 24:44 NIV*

This is what I told you while I was still with you: Everything must be fulfilled that is written about me in the Torah of Moses, the Prophets, and the Psalms.

Key Words Adapted by Teacher

The “blessed one” of [Psalm 1:1-6](#) is portrayed as the ideal Joshua seen in [Joshua 1:7-8](#), “one who meditates on the Torah day and night,” which results in success and a prosperous way.

Luke 11:50-51a NIV

Therefore, this generation will be held responsible for the blood of all the prophets that has been shed since the beginning of the world, from the blood of Abel to the blood of Zechariah, who was killed between the altar and the sanctuary.

Abel was murdered by Cain in [Genesis 4](#), and Zechariah son of Jehoiada was murdered by Joash in [2 Chronicles 24](#), which corresponds to the TaNaK order.

Other published texts in this time period also refer to the three-part design of the TaNaK.

“Many great teachings have been given to us through the Law (*Torah*), and the Prophets (*Nevi'im*), and the others that follow them (*Ketuvim*) ... So my grandfather Yeshua devoted himself especially to the reading of the Law and the Prophets and the other scrolls of our Ancestors.”

Prologue to the Wisdom of Ben Sirach

“The scrolls of Moses, the words of the prophets, and of David.”

Dead Sea Scrolls (4QMMT)

“The laws and the oracles given by inspiration through the prophets and the Psalms, and the other scrolls whereby knowledge and piety are increased and completed.”

Philo of Alexandria (De Vita Contemplativa, 25)

Reflection Question

What are the three parts of the ancient TaNaK order, and what are the main differences when compared to our modern English Bibles?